

BOOK 1 OF THE HOLLOW DOMINION

THE DREAMING GATE

A D&D 5e Adventure for Levels 1-3

3-4 Sessions | 3-5 Players

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ADVENTURE SUMMARY

A kingdom cursed by the death-throes of a dreaming god

BACKGROUND

Six months ago, the god Mordath — divine patron of dreams and creator of the Hollow Dominion — foresaw his own death. In his terror, a fragment of his psyche split away and gained sentience: **The Architect**, a parasitic entity that wears Mordath's fear like a crown and seeks to consume his divine essence. As Mordath's life force drains away, his dying dreams spill into the mortal world, warping reality across the Dominion. The landscape twists, nightmare creatures emerge from thin points between worlds, and the populace is trapped in a kingdom slowly becoming a realm of endless nightmare.

The player characters are **Dreambound** — souls tethered to Mordath's fading consciousness by a shared vision. They cannot leave until the curse is broken, and if Mordath dies without resolution, they die with him. Their only hope is to find the **Three Keys** — fragments of Mordath's divine essence scattered across the Dominion.

The adventure spans **three parts**: arrival at the Ashen Gate; investigation in Drearym, where faction tensions threaten to tear the town apart; and the climactic assault on the Gatehouse of Dreams, where the party must face the Nightmare Knight and enter Mordath's dying mind.

ADVENTURE DETAILS		KEY NPCS	
System	D&D 5e	Eldon Voss	Gatekeeper, former captain
Levels	1-3	Capt. Ashford	Waking Guard commander
Sessions	3-4	Brother Caelum	Dreamseeker priest
Players	3-5	Marta Greel	Innkeeper, Lissa's mother
Tone	Dark fantasy mystery	Mordath	The Dreaming God (dying)
Play Time	8-12 hours	The Architect	Mordath's fear, main villain

ADVENTURE HOOK: THE SHARED DREAM

For three nights running, each player character has experienced the same vivid dream: a vast chamber of white stone, lit by starlight that seems to come from everywhere and nowhere. At the center sits a figure on a throne, robed in shimmering fabric that shifts between midnight blue and deep purple. Its face is hidden behind a mask of cracked porcelain, and from behind it comes a voice — ancient, kind, and desperate.

"Come. Please. Before it is too late. I have seen my death, and it is not what you think. The hollow ones stir in my dreams. They wear my fear like a crown. Find the three keys — the Architect, the Crown, the Heart — before they consume everything. I cannot hold on much longer. Please."

On the fourth morning, each character discovers a mark on their skin — a glowing sigil shaped like an eye within a crescent moon. The sigil cannot be removed by any means short of breaking the curse. It glows purple in darkness, burns warm near dream-energy, and marks the bearer as **Dreambound** — tethered to Mordath's fate. The characters find themselves drawn westward, following an instinct they cannot explain, toward a misty archway that has appeared where none existed before: the **Ashen Gate**, the entrance to the Hollow Dominion.

DM Note: The shared dream is Mordath's final attempt to reach beyond the Dominion for help. The Architect is aware of this and will attempt to intercept or corrupt the Dreambound before they can find the three keys. The sigil serves as both a curse (the characters cannot leave) and a tool (it grants Dreamsense — detect dream-energy within 30 feet).

FACTIONS OF THE HOLLOW DOMINION

The powers that shape the Dominion

THE WAKING GUARD * Symbol: Golden sun over a crossed sword. Leader: Captain Rena Ashford. HQ: Drearym Barracks. Strength: 45 soldiers. Alignment: Lawful Good. The Waking Guard holds the Dominion together. They maintain order in Drearym, patrol the Twisted March, and protect the populace from nightmare creatures. Underfunded and exhausted but unbroken. Captain Ashford's orders: protect the people, keep the roads open, do not engage the Dreamseekers unless provoked. Goals: Protect Drearym. Prevent the Dreamseekers from killing the god. Find a way to break the curse without sacrificing Mordath. Attitude: Cautiously welcoming. DC 12 Persuasion to gain trust; DC 15 for armory access or reinforcements.
THE DREAMSEEKERS › Symbol: Crescent moon with an eye. Leader: Brother Caelum (manipulated by The Architect). HQ: Old Town Chapel. Strength: ~60 members. Alignment: Neutral. A religious movement that believes killing Mordath will "free" the Dreambound. They are wrong — it will kill every Dreambound, including the players. The Architect uses Caelum to build an army of Unbound. Goals: Convert Dreambound through "sharing circles." Build an Unbound army. Kill Mordath. The Architect's true goal: consume Mordath's divine essence.
THE VEIL COURT ◻ Symbol: Silver crown over a purple veil. Leader: Queen Thessaly (missing). HQ: The Fractured Court (ruined capital). Strength: ~20 nobles. The remnants of the Dominion's nobility, clinging to power in the ruins. They have the Silver Key (the Crown) but do not know its true significance.
THE UNBOUND ◻ Leader: None (controlled by The Architect). Strength: ~200 and growing. Alignment: Chaotic Evil. Former Dreambound consumed by nightmare energy. Partially translucent, crumbling, purple-eyed. Created through Dreamseeker "sharing circles." They are mindless servants of The Architect.

FACTION NPCs & CREATURES

Stat blocks for key faction members and enemies

WAKING GUARD SOLDIER

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), LAWFUL GOOD

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14	12	12	10	11	10
+2	+1	+1	+0	+0	+0

AC 16 (chain mail) | HP 11 (2d8+2) | Speed 30 ft.

Longsword. +4 to hit, 1d8+2 slashing. Light Crossbow. +3 to hit, 1d8 piercing, 80/320ft.

Shield Wall. Adjacent to another Guard with shield: +1 AC.

CAPTAIN RENA ASHFORD

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), LAWFUL GOOD

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16	12	14	10	14	13
+3	+1	+2	+0	+2	+1

AC 16 (chain mail, shield) | HP 45 (6d8+12) | Speed 30 ft.

Saves: STR +5, CON +4 | Skills: Athletics +5, Intimidation +3, Perception +4

Longsword. +5 to hit, 1d8+3 slashing. Signal Horn (1/day). Summons 2d4 Guards in 1d4 rounds.

DREAMSEEKER ACOLYTE

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), NEUTRAL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10	12	10	12	14	14
+0	+1	+0	+1	+2	+2

AC 11 (leather) | HP 9 (2d8) | Speed 30 ft.

Spellcasting (Cleric 1): DC 12, +4 to hit. Cantrips: guidance, sacred flame. 1st (2): command, cure wounds.

Convert (1/day). One willing Dreambound touched: DC 13 WIS or 1 exhaustion (3 levels = Unbound).

BROTHER CAELUM

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), NEUTRAL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10	12	10	14	16	18
+0	+1	+0	+2	+3	+4

AC 13 (chain shirt) | HP 32 (5d8+10) | Speed 30 ft.

Skills: Deception +6, Insight +5, Persuasion +8, Religion +4

Spellcasting (Cleric 5): DC 13, +5 to hit. 1st (4): command, cure wounds, sanctuary, shield of faith. 2nd (3): hold person, spiritual weapon, augury. 3rd (2): spirit guardians, dispel magic.

Dreamseeker's Blessing: Detect thoughts at will (bonus action).

THE UNBOUND

MEDIUM UNDEAD, CHAOTIC EVIL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10	6	14	6	8	8
+0	-2	+2	-2	-1	-1

AC 12 | HP 22 (4d8+4) | Speed 30 ft.

Slam. +4 to hit, 2d6+2 psychic damage. Mindless: Immune to charm, fright, and psychic damage.

PART 1: THE ASHEN GATE

The entrance to the Hollow Dominion

DANGER ●●○○○

ARRIVAL

"The archway rises from the mist like a broken tooth. Once-grand stone, now cracked and leaking purple dream-energy that makes your sigil burn warm. Beyond the gate, trees grow sideways and the road shifts when you're not looking."

The Ashen Gate is the only known entrance. Passing through is one-way. Characters who touch the purple energy must make a **DC 12 WIS save** or experience a brief vision of Mordath's throne room.



Eldon Voss — The Gatekeeper, former captain of the Waking Guard

ENCOUNTER: ELDON VOSS, THE GATEKEEPER

An old man sits on a mossy stone beside the gate, whittling with a rusted knife. His guard captain's uniform is tattered but the golden sun insignia is still visible. His eyes are sharp despite the grey stubble and thousand-yard stare.

"You're Dreambound. Welcome to the nightmare, friends. Mind the roads after dark. Things come through from the Dreaming Depths when the sun goes down."

Eldon is a font of information — but his mind is fractured. He drifts between lucid moments and confused rambling. When focused, he provides detailed directions, warns about thin points, and explains faction tensions. When confused, he relives battles from six months ago.

- ◆ The Dominion has been cursed for **six months**
- ◆ The landscape warps unpredictably — paths change, distances stretch
- ◆ **Nightmare creatures** emerge at dusk from thin points
- ◆ The **Waking Guard** maintain order; the **Dreamseekers** want Mordath dead
- ◆ "Don't sleep near running water — that's where the nightmares come through strongest."
- ◆ The Dreamseekers are "harvesting" Dreambound — converting them into Unbound

Social: DC 12 Persuasion for specific info. DC 10 Insight for lucid vs. rambling. Kindness earns a **hand-drawn map** (advantage on Survival checks).

DM NOTE

Eldon was once a respected captain. If hostile, he becomes incoherent. If trusted, he becomes a recurring ally who can send messages to Captain Ashford.

THE TWISTED MARCH

Three days through nightmare-ravaged countryside

DANGER ●●●○○

THE TWISTED ROAD

The road from the Ashen Gate to Drearym is called the **Twisted March** — a three-day journey through forest warped by Mordath's dying dreams. Trees grow at impossible angles, streams run purple with dream-energy, and distances change with the time of day. The air feels thick and wrong. Sounds carry strangely — a whisper echoes for miles, a shout is swallowed by mist. The party's Dreambound sigils burn warmer as they travel deeper. Travel is slow: 12 miles per day. Paths loop back on themselves, hills rise and fall like breathing things, and the stars rearrange into patterns that hurt to look at.

DAY 1 — THE WAKING GUARD OUTPOST

Halfway through the first day, the party reaches a fortified camp. **Sergeant Dara Voss** (Eldon's niece) commands 4 guards. She offers safe rest, rations, and information. She confirms the Dreamseekers are "recruiting" Dreambound — and those who join don't come back the same. She warns about the Wellspring: "We lost two men there last week."

DAY 2 — THE RUINED TOWER OF VALDRIS

A wizard's tower consumed by dream-energy. The stone walls shift between solid rock and translucent purple crystal. DC 14 Investigation finds a hidden journal page: "*Mordath spoke to us in dreams. 'I have seen my death. The Architect stirs in my dreams. It wants to wear my crown.'*" DC 12 Arcana reveals the thin point here is growing stronger.

DAY 3 — APPROACHING DREARYM

The final day is the most dangerous. The warping intensifies, and the party may encounter Unbound shambling through the trees. Drearym's walls appear on the horizon by late afternoon. The guards at the gate are wary, and the party's Dreambound marks will be noted.

D	8	
E	v	e n t
1	Shifting Path: DC 12 Survival or lose 1d4 hours + 1 exhaustion.	
2	Dream Echo: DC 13 WIS or 1 exhaustion.	
3	Nightmare Wolf: Attacks from treeline. Flees at half HP.	
4	Traveler: Refugee warns about Dreamseeker harvesting.	
5	Dream Shimmer: Find the three keys. DC 14 WIS or 2d6 psychic.	
6	Waking Guard Outpost: Safe rest, rations, information.	
7	Thin Point: DC 13 CON or pulled into dream vision.	
8	Peaceful Stretch: Recover 1 exhaustion, short rest.	

MAP: THE TWISTED MARCH

Regional map and encounter details



The Twisted March — Forest clearing with purple pools marking thin points between worlds.

LANDMARKS

- ◆ **Ashen Gate (South):** Entry point. Meet Eldon Voss. The point of no return.
- ◆ **Waking Guard Outpost:** Day 1. Sgt. Dara Voss, 4 guards. Safe haven with supplies.
- ◆ **The Wellspring:** Day 1-2. Ancient well leaking purple energy. Side quest: rescue Lissa Greel.
- ◆ **Ruined Tower of Valdris:** Day 2. Wizard's tower consumed by dream-energy. Hidden journal page.
- ◆ **Purple Pools:** Thin points between worlds. Nightmare creatures emerge after dark.
- ◆ **Drearym (North):** Day 3. First major town. Faction tensions.



Nightmare Wolf — Shadow-wolf touched by dream-energy, emerges at dusk

NIGHTMARE WOLF

MEDIUM UNDEAD, CHAOTIC EVIL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14	14	12	6	12	8
+2	+2	+1	-2	+1	-1

AC 13 | HP 18 (2d8+4) | Speed 40 ft.

Resist: Bludgeoning, Piercing, Slashing from nonmagical attacks

Immune: Charm, Fright

Bite. +4 to hit, 2d4+2 piercing + 1d4 **psychic** damage.

Pack Tactics. Advantage on attack rolls if an ally is within 5ft of target.

Dream Vulnerability: +1d6 radiant from moonlight effects. Flees at half HP.

DM NOTE

Nightmare Wolves hunt in packs of 1d4+1. They emerge at dusk from thin points and purple pools. They flee at half HP, retreating to the Dreaming Depths. If killed, their bodies dissolve into purple mist within 1 round.

PART 2: THE TOWN OF DREARYM

A town on the edge of collapse

DANGER ●●●○○

ARRIVAL

"Drearym was once a prosperous market town of 2,000. Now it holds perhaps 800. A makeshift wall of sharpened logs surrounds the town. Purple mist hovers in the alleys. Some buildings lean at impossible angles."

The town is under martial law. The Waking Guard controls the gates. The party's Dreambound marks will be noted — some townsfolk will be hostile, others desperate for help.

A — THE VIGOROUS DOG (INN)

A ramshackle two-story building with a painted sign of a running dog. The common room is warm but crowded with refugees. **Marta Greel** runs the place with a firm hand and a hand crossbow under the bar. Rooms are 5sp/night. She offers **50gp** for her daughter **Lissa**, missing near the Wellspring for three days. Marta is a former adventurer who lost her leg to a nightmare creature. "If you find my girl, bring her home. I don't care if she's scared or confused — just bring her home." The inn serves as an information hub — refugees trade rumors here, and Marta knows everything that happens in Drearym.

B — WAKING GUARD BARRACKS

A fortified stone building near the north gate, flying the Waking Guard's sun banner. **Captain Rena Ashford** commands 12 soldiers from here. She's stern but fair, and she's been holding the town together through sheer will for six months. She asks the party to investigate nightmare sightings on the eastern road (**30gp reward**). She warns about Brother Caelum: "That priest is going to get people killed with his talk of killing the god." The barracks has a locked armory (DC 15) containing spare weapons, armor, and a *Potion of Healing*. The guards here can provide information about patrol schedules, known thin points, and recent Unbound sightings.

C — OLD TOWN CHAPEL

Once a peaceful house of worship dedicated to Mordath, now the meeting place of the **Dreamseekers**. The old holy symbols have been defaced and replaced with crescent moon sigils. **Brother Caelum** preaches to crowds of desperate Dreambound every evening at dusk, telling them that killing Mordath will "free" them. He's charismatic and genuinely believes he's saving people — but he's being manipulated by The Architect. The chapel has a secret basement (DC 14 Perception to find the hidden door behind the altar) with a ritual chamber where Caelum conducts his "sharing circles" — gatherings where Dreambound are slowly drained of life force and converted into Unbound. DC 13 Investigation finds evidence of the conversion rituals: drained candles, purple-stained circles on the floor, and journal entries describing the process.

D — MARKET SQUARE

The central gathering place of Drearym. A weathered notice board holds missing persons flyers (including Lissa Greel's), bounty notices for nightmare creatures (50gp per Nightmare Wolf, 100gp per Nightmare Spawn), and a Dreamseeker recruitment poster. Refugees have set up a camp in the eastern corner, trading information and supplies. A hooded figure (DC 14 Perception to notice) watches the party from the shadows — a Dreamseeker spy who reports their arrival to Brother Caelum within the hour. Market stalls sell basic supplies at inflated prices: rations (10sp), torches (5sp), rope (5sp), healing potions (75gp).

DREARYM — KEY LOCATIONS

Town map and detailed location descriptions

E — THE WELLSPRING
An ancient stone well outside the eastern wall, now leaking purple dream-energy. The water has turned violet and bubbles with otherworldly light. Lissa Greel was last seen here, sitting at the well's edge with eyes open but unseeing — trapped in a Dream Loop, reliving her favorite memory on repeat. The area is dangerous: 2 Nightmare Spawn guard the well, and more emerge after dark. Within 10ft of the well is difficult terrain (ground made soft by dream-energy). Within 5ft requires a DC 12 WIS save or be pulled 5ft toward the well. The well is 15ft deep, filled with glowing purple liquid. Characters who touch the liquid must make a DC 13 CON save or be pulled into a brief dream vision (DM's choice: lore, foreshadowing, or a glimpse of Book 2 locations).
F — NORTH GATE
The main entrance to Drearym, controlled by the Waking Guard. Two guards in chain mail check everyone entering and leaving, noting Dreambound marks in a ledger. Curfew is enforced after sunset — anyone caught outside after dark is detained until dawn. The guards are sympathetic to Dreambound but follow Captain Ashford's orders without question. DC 12 Persuasion to pass without full inspection. The gate is reinforced with iron bands and can be barred in case of attack. A small shrine to Mordath sits beside the gate — one of the few that hasn't been defaced by the Dreamseekers. Characters who pray here (10 minutes) gain advantage on their next WIS save against nightmare effects.



Drearym — Letters mark key locations. Purple water flows through the settlement.

EXPLORING DREARYM — GENERAL NOTES
Population: ~800 (down from 2,000 before the curse). Atmosphere: Fear, exhaustion, and desperation. The purple-tinged water flowing through the streets is a constant reminder of the curse. Dreambound: Approximately 50 Dreambound currently reside in Drearym. They are viewed with pity by some, suspicion by others. Thin Points: Three known thin points exist within the town: the Wellspring (east), the Old Town Chapel basement (southeast), and beneath the Market Square well (center). Nightmare creatures can emerge from any of these after dark. Curfew: Sunset to dawn. Guards patrol in pairs. Rumors: DC 12 Persuasion at the Vigorous Dog to learn: (1) Queen Thessaly was seen near the Fractured Court three months ago. (2) The Architect has been spotted in dreams, wearing a crown of purple light. (3) A group of Unbound was seen marching south toward the Gatehouse.

NPCS OF THE DOMINION

Portraits and stat blocks for key characters



Captain Rena Ashford — Commander of the Waking Guard

CAPTAIN RENA ASHFORD

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), LAWFUL GOOD

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16	12	14	10	14	13
+3	+1	+2	+0	+2	+1

AC 16 (chain mail, shield) | HP 45 (6d8+12) | Speed 30 ft.

Saves: STR +5, CON +4 | **Skills:** Athletics +5, Intimidation +3, Perception +4

Longsword. +5 to hit, 1d8+3 slashing. *Signal Horn (1/day).* Summons 2d4 Guards in 1d4 rounds.

Personality: Stern, fair, exhausted. She's been holding the town together for six months.



Brother Caelum — Dreamseeker priest, manipulated by The Architect

BROTHER CAELUM

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), NEUTRAL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10	12	10	14	16	18
+0	+1	+0	+2	+3	+4

AC 13 (chain shirt) | HP 32 (5d8+10) | Speed 30 ft.

Skills: Deception +6, Insight +5, Persuasion +8, Religion +4

Spellcasting (Cleric 5): DC 13, +5 to hit. *Cantrips:* guidance, sacred flame, thaumaturgy. *1st (4):* command, cure wounds, sanctuary, shield of faith. *2nd (3):* hold person, spiritual weapon, augury. *3rd (2):* spirit guardians, dispel magic.

Dreamseeker's Blessing: *Detect thoughts* at will (bonus action).

Personality: Charismatic, passionate, genuinely believes killing Mordath will save everyone.

MARTA GREEL & THE DREAMING WELL

The innkeeper, the missing girl, and the nightmare spawn



Marta Greel — Innkeeper of The Vigorous Dog, former adventurer, mother of Lissa

MARTA GREEL — INNKEEPER

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), CHAOTIC GOOD

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14	10	16	12	13	11
+2	+0	+3	+1	+1	+0

AC 12 | HP 27 (5d8+5) | Speed 20 ft. (peg leg)

Skills: Intimidation +2, Medicine +3, Survival +4

Equipment: Hand crossbow (+4, 1d6 piercing), peg leg (improvised, +4, 1d4+2)

Personality: Blunt, practical, fiercely protective. Lost her leg to a nightmare creature. Lissa is all she has left.

ENCOUNTER: THE DREAMING WELL

The Wellspring is a thin point between the waking world and Mordath's dreams. **Lissa Greel** sits at the well's edge, eyes open but unseeing, trapped in a Dream Loop. **2 Nightmare Spawn** guard the well.

Option 1 — Physical Pull: DC 14 STR. Nightmare Spawn attack. Failure = DC 13 WIS or stunned.

Option 2 — Enter the Dream: DC 13 WIS to enter. DC 13 Persuasion. Failure = 2d6 psychic.

Option 3 — Disrupt: DC 14 Arcana. Success = Spawn take 3d6 radiant.



Nightmare Spawn — Shadow creatures that drain the life force of the living

NIGHTMARE SPAWN (RESKINNED SHADOW)

MEDIUM UNDEAD, CHAOTIC EVIL

AC 12 | HP 16 (3d8+3) | Speed 40 ft.

Strength Drain. +4 to hit, 2d6+2 **psychic**. STR -1d4. STR 0 = Unbound in 1d4 rounds.

Nightmare Aura: 10ft, DC 11 WIS or frightened. **Amorphous, Shadow Stealth**

PART 3: THE GATEHOUSE OF DREAMS

The boundary between worlds

DANGER ●●●●●



The Gatehouse of Dreams — Ancient monastery consumed by dream-energy

THE GATEHOUSE

A fortress built into a sheer cliff — the last outpost before the boundary dissolves into Mordath's consciousness. Purple dream-stuff seeps through cracks, pooling on floors that shift between rock and liquid starlight. The central courtyard's fountain bubbles endlessly. The air is thick with psychic residue — whispers of Mordath's dreams, visions of things to come. Dreamsense is amplified: all Dreambound within 60ft detected. After 1 hour inside, DC 12 WIS or 1 exhaustion from psychic strain.

THE FOUR WINGS

- ◆ **Dormitory (West):** DC 13 Investigation: journal page about The Architect.
- ◆ **Library (North):** Mordath was a mortal who ascended. The Architect is his fear.
- ◆ **Chapel (East):** 3 Nightmare Spawn. DC 13 WIS or vision of Mordath pleading.
- ◆ **Gate Hall (South):** The Dreaming Gate — portal to Mordath's throne room.

THE GATE HALL

"The Gate Hall opens onto the cliff edge. Before you stands the Dreaming Gate — thirty feet tall, filled with swirling purple energy. Through the portal: a white throne room. On the throne sits a figure robed in starlight, mask of cracked porcelain. Dying."

Between you and the portal stands a figure in purple armor, twin blades of crackling pink energy. It does not speak. But you feel its sorrow.

MORDATH — THE DREAMING GOD

Beyond the Dreaming Gate lies Mordath's throne room — the heart of the dying god's consciousness. If the party succeeds in reaching him, they will find not a monster, but a broken deity: a figure robed in fading starlight, mask of cracked porcelain, barely clinging to existence. Mordath is not combatable in the traditional sense — he is a dying god, not a boss encounter. His role is to deliver the quest for the Three Keys and provide the emotional climax of Book 1.

If the party reaches Mordath: He thanks them for coming, explains the nature of the Three Keys, and warns them about The Architect. He grants each character **Dreamsense** (detect dream-energy within 30 feet, always active) and a vision of the three locations where the Keys can be found. He then fades, asking them to "find the keys before the hollow ones consume everything."

MORDATH — THE DREAMING GOD

DIVINE BEING (DYING), NEUTRAL GOOD

AC 20 (divine aura) | HP 1 (cannot be reduced below 1 by any means) | Speed 0 ft. (bound to throne)

Immune: All damage types; All conditions

Divine Presence: All creatures within 30ft must DC 15 WIS save or be overwhelmed with sorrow (disadvantage on attacks for 1 round).

Dreamsense Aura: All Dreambound within 1 mile can sense Mordath's location and emotional state.

Not a Combat Encounter: Mordath cannot attack or be attacked. He is a narrative encounter — the emotional climax of Book 1. If the party attempts to harm him, their weapons pass through him like smoke, and he looks at them with infinite sadness.

If The Architect reaches Mordath first: The god dies, every Dreambound dies with him, and the Hollow Dominion becomes a realm of endless nightmare. This is the stakes for Books 2-5.

BOSS: THE NIGHTMARE KNIGHT

Guardian of the Dreaming Gate

DANGER ●●●●●



The Nightmare Knight — Dreambound soul with twin energy blades

THE GUARDIAN

The Nightmare Knight stands motionless before the Dreaming Gate, twin blades of crackling pink energy humming in its hands. Purple mist swirls around its armored feet, and through the narrow visor of its helmet, two points of magenta light burn like dying stars. It does not speak — it cannot. The curse that binds it has long since stolen its voice, its name, and nearly all memory of who it was in life. What remains is duty: an unbreakable oath to guard the gate between worlds, placed upon it in the final days before the monastery fell.

Once, the Knight was **Sir Aldric Voss** — Eldon's younger brother and the finest swordsman in the Waking Guard. When the curse first struck, Aldric led a desperate defense of the Gatehouse, holding the line against waves of nightmare creatures while the monks attempted to seal the Dreaming Gate. The ritual failed. The monks were consumed. Aldric was the last to fall — but instead of dying, his soul was bound to the gate by the very dream-energy he fought against. He has stood guard for six months, neither living nor dead, fighting off any who approach — not out of malice, but because he believes that anyone who touches the gate will suffer the same fate he did.

Social Encounter: The Knight can be reasoned with, though it communicates only through gestures and the emotions it projects. DC 15 Persuasion (DC 12 if the party has rescued Lissa or helped the Waking Guard — the Knight can sense its brother's approval through the Dreambound sigils). On success, it steps aside slowly, lowering its blades. A wave of sorrow washes over the party — not from the Knight, but from Mordath himself, grateful that someone has finally reached the gate. On failure, the Knight attacks, fighting defensively to push the party away from the portal.

Combat Encounter: Hard for level 3. The Knight fights with precision and restraint, using Dream Step to reposition rather than to flank. It targets the strongest-looking opponent first, attempting to disable rather than kill. It surrenders at 20 HP, dropping to one knee and gesturing toward the gate — a final act of duty fulfilled.

DM Note: If the party learns the Knight's true identity (DC 14 History or DC 12 Insight while observing its fighting style), they can call out "Aldric!" during the encounter. This gives advantage on the Persuasion check and causes the Knight to hesitate for 1 round, overwhelmed by the memory of its name.

NIGHTMARE KNIGHT

MEDIUM UNDEAD, LAWFUL NEUTRAL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18	14	18	12	14	16
+4	+2	+4	+1	+2	+3

AC 15 | HP 85 (10d8+40) | Speed 30 ft.

Multiattack. Two Energy Blades: +7, 2d6+4 slashing + 1d8 psychic.

Life Drain (Recharge 5-6). +7, 3d6+4 psychic, heals half. *Dream Step (Bonus).* Teleport 30ft.

Parry (Reaction). +3 AC. **Legendary (1/round):** *Reposition.* Move 15ft.

TOUCHING THE GATE

"The world dissolves into white. Three keys. Find them. The Architect wears my fear like a crown. The Crown lies in the Fractured Court. The Heart beats in the Dreaming Depths. Please. I cannot hold on much longer."

Each character gains **Dreamsense** (30ft, always active).

END OF BOOK 1

Mordath, the Three Keys, and the cliffhanger for Book 2

MORDATH — THE DYING GOD Through the Dreaming Gate, the party has glimpsed the truth: Mordath is not the enemy. He is a dying god — once a mortal who ascended to divinity through collective dreams, now consumed by his own fear of death. His curse is not malicious; it is a divine fever dream, the death-throes of a god who foresaw his own end. The purple dream-energy leaking into the Hollow Dominion is his life force, draining away as he fades. Mordath's final message: three keys can resolve the curse. "The Architect wears my fear like a crown. The Crown lies in the Fractured Court. The Heart beats in the Dreaming Depths." These are fragments of Mordath's divine essence — his authority, his sovereignty, and his compassion.
THE THREE KEYS The Bronze Key — The Architect: Mordath's own fear of death, given sentience. It manipulates the Dreamseekers through Brother Caelum to build an army. The Bronze Key can only be claimed by confronting the source of Mordath's fear. <i>Book 2: The Fractured Court.</i> The Silver Key — The Crown: Mordath's symbol of divine authority, lying in the ruins of the capital. Guarded by twisted former courtiers. <i>Book 3.</i> The Gold Key — The Heart: Mordath's divine compassion, beating in the Dreaming Depths beyond the waking world. Protected by the most powerful nightmare creatures and Mordath's own despair. <i>Book 4.</i>
CLIFFHANGER FOR BOOK 2 "As you leave the Gatehouse, you see them. A vast army of Unbound — hundreds strong — marching toward Drearym. At their head: Brother Caelum, eyes glowing purple. He's been converting Dreambound into Unbound, building an army to storm the Fractured Court and kill Mordath by force. And he's coming for you next." The party must return to Drearym and warn Captain Ashford — but the army is only days away. The race to find the three keys has begun. If the Architect reaches Mordath first, the god dies, every Dreambound perishes, and the Hollow Dominion becomes a realm of endless nightmare.
TREASURE & REWARDS Guardian's Longsword (<i>uncommon</i>) +1 longsword. +1d4 psychic vs undead/fiends. 1/day: <i>detect thoughts</i> (DC 13). Marta's Gratitude If Lissa rescued: <i>Potion of Greater Healing</i> + <i>Cloak of Elvenkind</i>. Monastery Journal 25gp. DC 15 History reveals Fractured Court location. Dreambound Sigil Identify Dreambound. Advantage on saves vs nightmare effects. Milestone: Party reaches level 3.
GM NOTES Tone: Waking up in someone else's nightmare. Mordath is not a villain — he's a dying god. Moral Complexity: Neither faction is wrong. The Guard wants to preserve Mordath. The Dreamseekers want to end the curse. Scaling: Level 1: Knight HP 60, no Legendary Actions. Level 4+: +2 Nightmare Spawn, Knight +10 HP.

THE HOLLOW DOMINION

A once-prosperous kingdom cursed by the death-throes of Mordath, the Dreaming God. His nightmares leak into the waking world — twisting landscapes, corrupting creatures, and driving the populace mad.

The players are Dreambound — souls tethered to Mordath's fading consciousness. They cannot leave until the curse is broken. But if Mordath dies, they die with him.

From the Ashen Gate to the Gatehouse of Dreams, the party must navigate nightmare-ravaged lands, choose which faction to trust, and find the three keys that can save the Dominion — or doom it forever.

D&D 5e | Levels 1-3 | 3-4 Sessions | 3-5 Players

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